Yichun Zhou

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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

NYU Shanghai, Shanghai, China **Jul. 2025 – Present**
· Postdoctoral Fellow in Urban Science, Shanghai Key Laboratory of Urban Design and Urban Science (LOUD). Advisor: Associate Professor ChengHe Guan

East China Normal University, Shanghai, China **Oct. 2025 – Present**
· Joint Postdoctoral Fellow in Urban Ecology, School of Ecological and Environmental Sciences, co-appointed with NYU Shanghai. Advisor: Professor Xiaoyong Chen

EDUCATION

New York University, Tandon School of Engineering, Brooklyn, NY **Sep. 2021 – May 2025**
· Ph.D. in Urban Systems
· Dissertation: *Investigating Urban Green Space Engagement Through Mobility Patterns and Visual Perceptions in High-Density Metropolitan Areas*
· Dissertation committee: Associate Professor ChengHe Guan, Assistant Professor Tyler Haupert, Professor Constantine Kontokosta, and Professor Shenjing He (The University of Hong Kong)

New York University, Tandon School of Engineering, Brooklyn, NY **Sep. 2019 – May 2021**
· M.S. in Management of Technology, Data Analytics Specialization

Western Kentucky University, Bowling Green, KY **Aug. 2015 – May 2019**
· B.S. in Computer Science, Ogden College of Science and Engineering, minor in Business Administration, *magna cum laude*

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Substantive: Urban science and urban analytics · Urban green and blue space planning · Human mobility and spatial behavior · Environmental health and equity

Methods: Geospatial data science · Causal inference and policy evaluation · Mobility data analytics · Computer vision for street-level imagery · Surveys, field experiments, and mixed methods · Microclimate and environmental measurement

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles (11 Published or Accepted)

[1] **Zhou, Y.**†, Ren, X.†, Yabe, T., & Guan, C. (2026). Seeing green, staying longer? A causal analysis of visual green exposure and urban park engagement using mobility and panoramas data. *Landscape and Urban Planning*, 268, 105579. († equal contribution)

[2] **Zhou, Y.**, Huang, X., Li, Z., Guo, Q. V., & Wei, H. (2026). Exponential distance decay in urban park visitation: A comparative analysis of recreational mobility across 20 U.S. metropolitan areas. *Landscape and Urban Planning*, 273, 105690.

[3] Wu, L., **Zhou, Y.**, Nie, X., & Guan, C. (2026). Enhancing subjective well-being through indoor and outdoor greenspace planning: Community and sociodemographic moderators during and after COVID-19 confinement. *Journal of Planning Education and Research*, 0739456X261449791.

[4] Lin, Q., **Zhou, Y.**, Quan, S. J., & Guan, C. (2026). Analyzing seasonal and nonlinear built environment-energy dynamics using street view imagery in New York City. *Sustainable Cities and Society*, 143, 107325.

[5] Wu, L., **Zhou, Y.**, Nie, X., Kim, S. K., Shao, Y., & Guan, C. (2026). Buffering effects of green space on residents' mental wellbeing: A regression discontinuity analysis during COVID containment policy shift. *Cities*, 168, 106413.

[6] Guan, C., Zhong, H., **Zhou, Y.**, Li, Y., Zhang, B., Chen, Z., Srinivasan, S., & Nielsen, C. P. (2026). Generational differences in active travel: Estimation, decomposition, and policy implications. *Applied Geography*, 191, 103997.

[7] Chen, J., Li, C., **Zhou, Y.**, Cheng, T., Yu, J., & Guan, C. (2026). Emotional divergence in urban climate discourse: Spatial patterns and semantic decoding across global cities. *npj Environmental Social Sciences* (accepted).

[8] Song, J., Guan, C., **Zhou, Y.**, Akiyama, Y., & Shibasaki, R. (2025). Visitor profile-oriented urban park categorization: Analyzing home-to-park trip characteristics using mobile phone data. *Journal of Planning Education and Research*, 0739456X251347237.

[9] **Zhou, Y.**, Guan, C., Wu, L., Li, Y., Nie, X., Song, J., Kim, S. K., & Akiyama, Y. (2024). Visitation-based classification of urban parks through mobile phone big data in Tokyo. *Applied Geography*, 167, 103300.

[10] Guan, C., & **Zhou, Y.** (2024). Exploring environmental equity and visitation disparities in peri-urban parks: A mobile phone data-driven analysis in Tokyo. *Landscape and Urban Planning*, 248, 105104.

[11] Wu, L., **Zhou, Y.**, Nie, X., Kim, S. K., Shao, Y., & Guan, C. (2024). "Unfenced" parks and residents' visit patterns: A regression discontinuity design in Shanghai. *Urban Forestry & Urban Greening*, 100, 128459.

Peer-Reviewed Conference Proceedings (3)

[1] **Zhou, Y.**, Song, X., & Zhou, M. (2021). Supply chain fraud prediction based on XGBoost method. *Proceedings of the 2021 IEEE 2nd International Conference on Big Data, Artificial Intelligence and Internet of Things Engineering (ICBAIE)*, pp. 539–542.

[2] **Zhou, Y.**, Cheng, Y., Lin, Y., & Tian, M. (2021). Sales forecasting using GBDT based model and data mining method. *2021 IEEE International Conference on Consumer Electronics and Computer Engineering (ICCECE)*, pp. 398–401.

[3] Teng, Y., Chen, D., **Zhou, Y.**, Vegh, N. M., & Zhang, R. (2020). A WaveNet based ion channel prediction method. *Journal of Physics: Conference Series*, 1651(1), 012009.

Manuscripts Under Review or Revision (6; * corresponding author)

[1] **Zhou, Y.**, Wu, T., Chen, J., & Guan, C. How perceived residential environments affect neighborhood park visitation? A nonlinear analysis of mobile and street view data. (Under review at *Applied Geography*)

[2] **Zhou, Y.**, Cheng, T., Wu, B., & Guan, C. Healthy cities for all ages? Age-differentiated perception effects and service infrastructure change from China's urban health policy. (Under review at *Cities*)

[3] **Zhou, Y.*** Real inequality or spatial artifact? A place-based analysis of environmental co-occurrence using city-scale walking-trajectory data. (Under review at *Health & Place*)

[4] **Zhou, Y.*** How the built environment shapes the rhythm and extent of urban walking: Causal evidence from GPS trajectories in Shanghai. (Under review at *Travel Behaviour and Society*)

[5] Yu, Y., & **Zhou, Y.*** Different greens for different residents: Heterogeneous associations between green space structure and collective efficacy in Shanghai. (Under review at *Journal of Urban Management*)

[6] Shan, L., Xu, T., **Zhou, Y.**, & Wang, L. AI-enhanced livable environment planning: Streetscape synergies on urban thermal environment and cycling vitality in Shanghai. (Revise and resubmit at *Cities*)

GRANTS AND FELLOWSHIPS

National Natural Science Foundation of China, Young Scientists Fund (Category C) **2027 – 2029**

· Principal Investigator, CNY 300,000. Association Mechanisms and Spatiotemporal Heterogeneity between Dynamic Exposure to Urban Blue-Green Space and Physical Activity Behaviors (Grant No. 52608119; awarded 2026)

Global NYU Postdoc Collaboration Grant, New York University **2026**

· Principal Investigator, USD 4,500. Mixed-methods pilot study on older adults, urban heat, and green space, with the NYU School of Global Public Health

Shanghai Postdoctoral Excellence Program (CNY 300,000) **2025 – 2027**

Shanghai Postdoctoral Overseas Recruitment Program (CNY 150,000) **2025 – 2027**

Postdoctoral Research and Professional Development Grant, New York University (USD 2,500) **2025**

Scholar Travel Fund, NYU Shanghai (CNY 6,000, 2024; CNY 3,000, 2026) **2024, 2026**

International GeoInformatics Summer School Scholarship, Wuhan University (CNY 7,950) **2024**

Sustainability Internship Grant, New York University (USD 3,500) **2023**

Merit Scholarship, Tandon School of Engineering, New York University (USD 14,000) **2019 – 2021**

Dean's Scholarship, Western Kentucky University (USD 3,000) **2016 – 2018**

AWARDS AND HONORS

Academic Oral Presentation Award, International Conference on Natural Resources and Planning **2026**

Saarinen Paper Award, AAG Environmental Perception and Behavioral Geography Specialty Group **2025**

Best Academic Contribution and Audience Choice Awards (team awards), AI4CITIES Workshop, Tongji University **2025**

Best Graduate Student Poster (First Place), AAG Middle States Division Annual Conference **2024**

Best Oral Presentation Award, Post-Doctoral and Doctoral Research Assembly, NYU Shanghai **2024**

President's List and Dean's List, Western Kentucky University **2016 – 2018**

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

16 presentations at international and national conferences

[1] Exponential distance decay in urban park visitation: A comparative analysis of recreational mobility across 20 U.S. metropolitan areas. (Aug. 2026). The 2026 City+ Academic Conference for Early Career and Young Researchers on Interdisciplinary Urban Studies (City+X: Xiaoshan Demo), Xiaoshan, Hangzhou, China.

[2] Seeing green, staying longer? A causal analysis of visual green exposure and urban park engagement using mobility and panoramas data. (Jun. 2026). The Association for Environmental Studies and Sciences (AESS) 2026 Conference, Online.

[3] Seeing green, staying longer? A causal analysis of visual green exposure and urban park engagement using mobility and panoramas data. (May 2026). The 9th Annual APRU Sustainable Cities and Landscapes Conference, School of Design, Shanghai Jiao Tong University, Shanghai, China.

[4] Exponential distance decay in urban park visitation: A comparative analysis of recreational mobility across 20 U.S. metropolitan areas. (Mar. 2026). 2026 International Conference on Natural Resources and Planning, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong SAR, China. (Academic Oral Presentation Award)

[5] Seeing green, staying longer? A causal analysis of visual green exposure and urban park engagement using mobility and panoramas data. (Mar. 2026). 2026 American Association of Geographers (AAG) Annual Meeting, San Francisco, CA, U.S.

[6] Seeing green, staying longer? A causal analysis of visual green exposure and urban park engagement using mobility and panoramas data. (Nov. 2025). 2025 Annual Conference on Behavioral Geography and Health Geography in China, Sun Yat-sen University, Guangzhou, China.

[7] A causal analysis of visual green exposure and urban park engagement. (Sep. 2025). City+2025@Oxford: The 8th International Conference on Interdisciplinary Urban Studies, University of Oxford, Oxford, UK.

[8] Nonlinear relationship between perceived residential environment and neighborhood park visitation. (Jul. 2025). 19th International Association for China Planning (IACP) Annual Conference, Xiamen University, Xiamen, China.

[9] How perceived residential environments affect neighborhood park visitation? (Jun. 2025). Urban China Research Network (UCRN) 2025 Conference, Sichuan University, Chengdu, China.

[10] Nonlinear relationship between perceived residential environment and neighborhood park visitation. (Mar. 2025). 2025 American Association of Geographers (AAG) Annual Meeting, Detroit, MI, U.S. (Online)

[11] Classification of urban parks through visitation patterns using mobile data. (Nov. 2024). 64th Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning (ACSP) Annual Conference, Seattle, WA, U.S.

[12] How perceived residential environments affect neighborhood park visitation? (Nov. 2024). The 2024 Middle States Division of the American Association of Geographers (MSAAG) Annual Conference, West Chester University, West Chester, PA, U.S. (Presentation and poster, Best Graduate Student Poster)

[13] Visitation-based classification of urban parks through mobile phone big data. (Jul. 2024). 18th International Association for China Planning (IACP) Annual Conference, Zhejiang University, Hangzhou, China.

[14] Classification of urban parks through visitation patterns using mobile phone data. (Apr. 2024). 2nd Annual Post-doctoral and Doctoral Research Assembly, NYU Shanghai, Shanghai, China. (Presentation and poster, Best Oral Presentation Award)

[15] Exploring environmental equity and visitation disparities in peri-urban parks. (Jan. 2024). Urban Systems Institute (USI) Inaugural Conference, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong SAR, China.

[16] Buffering effect of urban green space on mental health: A case study of Shanghai. (Dec. 2023). 2022 Built Environment Technology Center Open Topic Grants Conference, Tongji University, Shanghai, China.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching interests: Computational urban science and urban analytics · GIS and remote sensing · Urban green space and environmental planning · Human mobility and transportation · Urban environment and health · Research design and causal inference

SOCS-SHU 201 Planning Global Cities, NYU Shanghai · ***Workshop Lecturer / Teaching Fellow*** **Fall 2026**

- Lead the assignment component of the course, briefing students on research design and grading criteria, and handle in-class questions and assignment review.
- Design and lead field trips to urban green and public spaces in Shanghai.

SOCS-SHU 133 Urbanization in China, NYU Shanghai · ***Guest Lecturer*** **Spring 2026**

- Delivered a session on published research into causal relationships between visual green exposure and park engagement, connecting findings to course themes on urban environmental quality in Chinese cities.

SOCS-SHU 201 Planning Global Cities, NYU Shanghai · ***Workshop Lecturer / Teaching Fellow*** **Fall 2025**

- Designed and delivered three workshop sessions on systematic literature review methods and quantitative analytic techniques for 24 undergraduate students.
- Introduced spatial analysis, causal inference frameworks, and GIS-based urban assessment as applied to global city planning challenges.

SOCS-SHU 133 Urbanization in China, NYU Shanghai · ***Teaching Fellow*** **Spring 2025**

- Facilitated weekly discussion sessions on urbanization processes, covering neighborhood dynamics, green space provision, active travel, and sustainable urban planning.

URPL-GP 2250 Planning Global Cities, NYU Wagner · ***Workshop Lecturer*** **Fall 2024**

- Designed and led experiential learning field trips to urban green spaces and key urban landmarks in New York City for graduate students in urban planning.

SOCS-SHU 247 Computational Urban Science, NYU Shanghai · ***Workshop Lecturer*** **Fall 2022**

- Independently designed and delivered a technical workshop on Google Earth Engine for remote sensing analysis of urban landscapes, introducing 12 students to satellite imagery processing and land cover classification.

Department of Applied Physics, NYU Tandon · ***Graduate Assistant*** **Sep. 2019 – May 2021**

- Supported instruction across four semesters of undergraduate physics courses, preparing examination materials for quizzes, midterms, and final exams.

RESEARCH SUPERVISION

Graduate advisees: Juyan Chen, ECNU and NYU Shanghai Joint Graduate Program in Ecology, graduated 2026; Xinbei Wang, same program, graduated 2025, now a doctoral student at the University of Oxford.

Undergraduate advisees (NYU Shanghai): Nadine Ziyan Chen, Social Science (Urban Studies), Class of 2026, completed a Major Honors thesis, now in the master's program in Learning Design, Innovation, and Technology at Harvard University; Chengcheng Zhu, Data Science and Social Science, Class of 2028, ongoing; Zach Phelps, Social Science (Urban Studies), Class of 2029, ongoing; Yicheng Lyu, Data Science, Class of 2029, ongoing; Miles Lifton, Social Science, Class of 2028, prior advisee.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Urban Green Space, Heat, and Healthy Aging, New York, NY **Jun. 2026 – Present**

- Principal Investigator, Global NYU Postdoc Collaboration Grant (USD 4,500). Visiting Postdoctoral Researcher at the NYU School of Global Public Health in June 2026 (host: Assistant Professor Alexis Merdjanoff). Designed and carried out a mixed-methods pilot study of how Chinese-American older adults use parks as heat refuge and social infrastructure, combining microclimate measurement, behavioral observation, and semistructured interviews.

Chengdu and Shanghai Household Travel and Health Survey, China **Oct. 2025 – Present**

- Co-Investigator (Principal Investigator: Associate Professor ChengHe Guan). Co-designed the third wave of a 20-year household travel survey (n = 2,000, 40 communities) with Harvard University and Peking University, developing randomized experimental modules on information framing for active transportation and Park City green space utilization.

Smart Prosthetics and the Needs of Residents with Disabilities **Aug. 2025 – Jul. 2026**

- Core Researcher (Principal Investigator: Associate Professor ChengHe Guan), commissioned by the Zhejiang Foundation for Disabled Persons. Designed and conducted a mixed-methods study of people with limb loss (valid sample of 100 or more, spanning age, disability grade, and employment status), analyzing functional and affective needs for intelligent bionic prostheses.

Urban Green Spaces for Wellbeing, Peking University collaboration **Jun. 2023 – May 2026**

- Core Researcher (Principal Investigator: Assistant Professor Longfeng Wu). Co-authored three manuscripts applying regression discontinuity and moderation analyses to examine green space effects on mental wellbeing in Beijing and Shanghai.

South Africa PRASA Signalling and Telecommunications Programme **Jan. 2026 – Apr. 2026**

- Core Researcher (Principal Investigator: Associate Professor ChengHe Guan), commissioned by the New Development Bank. Conducted urban planning and multimodal transport analysis for the appraisal of a USD 1 billion rail signaling investment in South Africa, synthesizing international case studies and coordinating technical exchanges with industry partners.

Big Data-Based Urban Renewal Research, Shanghai, China **Jul. 2024 – Oct. 2025**

- Core Researcher (Principal Investigator: Associate Professor ChengHe Guan), commissioned by the Shanghai Digital Governance Research Institute. Led spatiotemporal analysis of suburban park visitation and 15-minute life circle optimization using big data, authoring two research reports and designing a data analytics dashboard.

The Path Toward Climate Park Community, Biennale Architettura 2025 **Apr. 2024 – Oct. 2025**

· Project Member (Principal Investigators: Assistant Professor of Practice Ying Li and Associate Professor ChengHe Guan). Compiled case study materials and prepared presentation and submission documents for the Venice Architecture Biennale 2025 exhibition on climate-responsive park community planning.

AI and Climate Futures in Asia, Digital Futures Lab, Remote **Jan. 2023 – Dec. 2023**

· Project Member (Principal Investigator: Dr. Urvashi Aneja), supported by the Rockefeller Foundation. Co-authored a policy report synthesizing evidence on AI applications for climate-resilient urban planning.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Journal Peer Review

Landscape and Urban Planning; *Cities*; *Urban Forestry & Urban Greening*; *Applied Geography*; *Journal of Transport Geography*; *Journal of Environmental Studies and Sciences*; *Journal of Urban Management*; *City and Environment Interactions*; *Journal of Asian Architecture and Building Engineering*; *Journal of Parks*

Conference Organization and Moderation

NYU Shanghai Global Institute for Longevity and Resilience Inaugural Conference, Shanghai, China
Moderator, Earth Systems and Urban Resilience Parallel Forum Sep. 17, 2026
2026 City+X: Xiaoshan Demo Conference, Session Chair Aug. 2026
Shanghai Climate Week 2026, Opening Ceremony Moderator Apr. 2026
Shanghai Climate Week 2026 Healthy Cities Sub-Forum, Organizing Committee Member Apr. 2026
4th Future Cities Hangzhou Forum, Session Chair Jun. 2025
18th IACP Annual Conference, Session Chair Jul. 2024
2023 Urban Development Forum, Shanghai, Organizing Committee Member Oct. 2023

Professional Associations

Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning (ACSP) · American Association of Geographers (AAG) · Urban Affairs Association (UAA) · International Society for Urban Health (ISUH) · The New York Academy of Sciences (NYAS) · International Association for China Planning (IACP)

Community Engagement

City+ (city-plus.org), 2025 – Present; GISphere (gisphere.info), 2024 – 2025

METHODS AND TOOLS

Programming and tools: Python, R, SQL, ArcGIS, QGIS, Stata, Google Earth Engine, Tableau

Methods and data: Causal inference (matching, weighting, regression discontinuity), computer vision for street-level imagery (semantic segmentation), mobility big data (mobile phone signaling, GPS trajectories), survey and field experimental design, microclimate and environmental field measurement

Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native), English (proficient)

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

Amazon Web Services, Shanghai · *Program Management Intern* **Mar. 2021 – Aug. 2021**

· Optimized candidate prioritization processes for manufacturing and technical hiring pipelines.

Bosch (China) Investment Ltd., Shanghai · *Data Science Intern* **Sep. 2020 – Feb. 2021**

· Developed machine learning algorithms for lane change detection and road surface wetness monitoring using vehicle sensor data.

Tencent Holdings Ltd., Shenzhen · *Data Science Intern* **Jun. 2020 – Aug. 2020**

· Improved sensor data quality pipelines for environmental early warning systems.